MODULE 8

Most professionals don't have a career direction. They have a career title they're hoping to reach.

Those are not the same thing — and only one of them produces intentional, accelerating growth.

1

CAREER DIRECTION

A North Star is not a job title. It is a direction that survives reorganizations, pivots, and bad years.

- Most professionals have vague aspirations and no plan to close the gap between where they are and where they want to be.
- The gap between the career you want and the career you're currently building is your development roadmap.
- Career clarity is not a luxury. It is the prerequisite for every deliberate professional investment.

KEY INSIGHT

If you looked back in five years and your career had gone exactly as you hope — what would be different about your day-to-day work?

Advancement is not a merit system. It is a relationship and visibility system with merit as the baseline requirement.

- The three dimensions: Performance (necessary, not sufficient), Potential (differentiating), Positioning (deciding).
- The manager who is excellent but invisible loses to the manager who is good and known.
- Most managers have never had a direct, specific advancement conversation with their manager. That is the first fix.

KEY INSIGHT
If your administrator were asked right now whether you're ready for the next level, what would they say? Is that the answer you want?

3 PERSONAL BRAND

Your professional brand is not what you say about yourself. It is what people say about you when you're not in the room.

- Most professionals have never deliberately defined their brand. Their reputation has formed by default.
- The five-word exercise: ask five colleagues to describe how you show up professionally. What do they say?
- The gap between how you intend to show up and how you actually land — that gap is your brand work.

KEY INSIGHT

What word do you most want to be in someone's five-word description of you — that isn't reliably there yet?

4 LINKEDIN PROFILE

When your name comes up in a room you're not in, someone will search it. What will they find?

- Most healthcare managers have LinkedIn profiles that were created years ago and never meaningfully updated.
- Headline: Role + Specialty + Value. Not just your job title. Your job title doesn't differentiate you.
- Experience bullets: lead with impact, not duties. Every bullet should contain at least one number.

KEY INSIGHT
If a senior leader looked at your LinkedIn profile right now, would it represent you as the professional you actually are?

Your expertise is only valuable to people who know it exists.

- The Visibility Ladder: seven rungs from thoughtful meeting contributions to published thought leadership.
- Original content from direct professional experience is the most credible content you can publish.
- Consistency compounds. Twelve posts a year for three years is more powerful than one viral post.

KEY INSIGHT
What do you know from direct experience in healthcare management that most people in your field haven't said out loud?

Leadership is not a destination. It's a practice. The program ends. The practice doesn't.

- Personal Board of Directors: seven roles — mentor, sponsor, peer, challenger, expert, connector, supporter.
- Most professionals have mentors and no sponsors. A sponsor advocates for you in rooms you can't access.
- Post-program growth requires structure: one learning habit, one relationship investment, one visible contribution.

KEY INSIGHT
Who in your professional life is positioned to advocate for you when an opportunity arises? If you can't name them, that's the work.

FRAMEWORK

The Three Advancement Dimensions

Understanding why some managers advance and others don't is less complicated than most people think.

1. Performance: consistent delivery above expectations in the current role. Required — but not sufficient.
2. Potential: demonstrable capability beyond the current scope — strategic thinking, leading others, initiative.
3. Positioning: visibility with decision-makers. A clear narrative. Being known for the right things.
4. Most managers invest heavily in Performance and almost nothing in Positioning.
5. Positioning is not self-promotion. It is ensuring the people who make decisions have the information they need to make a good one about you.

REFLECT ON THIS

The career you want doesn't find you. You build it — deliberately.

What is the gap between the career you want in five years and the career you are currently building? Can you name it specifically?

TRY THIS

Three career development actions for this week:

1. Write the opening sentence of the advancement conversation you've been postponing. Schedule it.
2. Ask five colleagues for five words. Record every one. Note what surprises you.
3. Rewrite your LinkedIn headline: Role + Specialty + Value. Publish it before Friday.

The Focused Leader

Module 8 · Career Advancement & Personal Brand

This is Module 8 of 8.

The full series: 8 modules, 40 competencies.

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